

Hoodie

One page, already written, asking that a student wear a hoodie instead of the blazer.

Reach for it when you need to hand the school a reason in writing, today.

[Student name] will wear a plain hoodie in the future rather than the school blazer. This is because the texture and fit of the blazer are uncomfortable and distract them from engaging comfortably in learning. Likewise, the hood enables them to screen out sensory clutter and facilitates concentration.

Uniform adjustments: hard collars, ties, leather school shoes, formal skirts and trousers, these can all be difficult to manage for many autistic people. The use of more comfortable fabrics can allow us to concentrate more fully on our tasks. Many schools now encourage children to attend school with trainers and a school hoodie for comfort and practicality.

— Children and Young People — Autism Understanding Scotland (<https://www.autismunderstanding.scot/information-hub/children-young-people>)

Relaxing or scrapping school uniform policies supports pupils with sensory issues who cannot tolerate wearing the uniform.

— Neurodiversity-affirmative education: why and how? | The British Psychological Society (<https://www.bps.org.uk/psychologist/neurodiversity-affirmative-education-why-and-how>)

“I have to check the texture of fabrics when I’m clothes shopping. Anything rough or crunchy I can’t wear. I also need soft and stretchy fabrics.”

— PsyArXiv Preprints | In our own words: The complex sensory experiences of autistic adults (<https://osf.io/preprints/psyarxiv/3nk7a>)

Promote sensory-friendly clothing choices.

— Autistic SPACE: a novel framework for meeting the needs of autistic people in healthcare settings | British Journal of Hospital Medicine (<https://www.magonlinelibrary.com/doi/full/10.12968/hmed.2023.0006>)

May find aspects of school uniform (or other clothes) difficult or impossible – reasonable adjustment needed.

– [Autism, Girls, & Keeping It All Inside](https://s3.eu-central-1.amazonaws.com/up.raindrop.io/...) (s3.eu-central-1.amazonaws.com/up.raindrop.io/...)

We can't stim, are subject to rules around when we can go to the bathroom and forced into chafing uniforms that are, frankly, a sensory hell.

– [“No attendance score is worth your suffering” — Neurodiverse Connection](https://ndconnection.co.uk/blog/...) (ndconnection.co.uk/blog/...)

The picture shows a school classroom as I see it, as an autistic person. A kaleidoscope of shape and blinding lighting, with vague outlines which are probably other students. Deafening noise. The stench of different smells. The confusion of many voices, including some heard through walls from neighbouring halls and classes. School uniform that feels like barbed wire on my skin.

– [Ann's Autism Blog: Autism, School, Exclusion. What's fair?](https://annsautism.blogspot.com/2018/08/autism-school-exclusion-whats-fair.html) (https://annsautism.blogspot.com/2018/08/autism-school-exclusion-whats-fair.html)

What to Ask For in the Room

This sheet is already the request. These are the things to ask for alongside it, so the answer holds.

- **Ask for it in writing, in the plan.** A verbal agreement with one teacher lasts until that teacher is away, and then it is the child's job to re-argue it at the door.
- **Ask that it not be revisited each term.** A sensory need is not a trial period. Re-opening it every September means a child spends every September braced for it.
- **Ask that it apply everywhere the uniform does** — assembly, trips, photographs, exams. An adjustment with exceptions is an adjustment that fails on the days that are hardest anyway.
- **Ask that no condition be attached.** Not "as long as behaviour is good", not "as long as grades hold". An access need is not a reward, and making it one guarantees it is withdrawn on the day it is needed most.
- **Ask what else in the uniform is doing this.** The blazer is rarely the only item. Collars, ties, waistbands, and shoes are the usual rest of the list, and asking once is cheaper than asking four times.
- **Ask who else needs this and has not asked.** A policy that only bends for the children whose parents can write this letter is a policy that sorts by parent, not by need.

Signatories

The following individuals, organizations, and communities endorse this Why Sheet (<https://stimpunks.org/why/>). Want to join them? Add your signature. (<https://stimpunks.org/fieldguide/operations/forms/sign-why-sheet/>)

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- Heidi Mavir (<https://www.heidimavir.com/>)
- Alice McSweeney (<https://neurodiversejourneys.com/>)
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- Autistic Revolution (<https://www.autistic-revolution.com>)
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- Katy Elphinstone (<https://www.neurofabulous.org.uk>)

- Jen Summers
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- Trisha Thompson (<https://www.instagram.com/intentionalteachingsolutions/>)
- Angela Kingdon, The Autistic Culture Podcast (<https://www.AutisticCulturePodcast.com>)
- Neurodivergent Infinity Network of Educators (<https://tinyurl.com/NINEsite>)
- Emily Marcus

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Where this sheet comes from. It is written and revised as Markdown in the open: [Hoodie.md](#). That file is the source this page and its PDF are both generated from, so the three cannot say different things.

This sheet is also published as a page on [stimpunks.org](#).